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MRIDULA USED TO TEACH ENGLISH AT A PRIMARY SCHOOL. HAVING lost that job six months ago, she had been offering home tuitions. Both she and Ranganath struggled to make ends meet. On the night of 2 August, Ranganath returned with Suresh Master. The latter had been told to accommodate a few more persons in the house for four days. He would move them to a new place after that. It was only a stop-gap arrangement.

Suresh Master had posed the question directly to Mridula and she was still struggling to come up with an answer when Ranganath suddenly took Suresh Master outside. While leaving the room, he signalled to her about more money coming in if there were more guests to accommodate. Within minutes, both were back with four more people—Amman, Sivarasan, Rangan and Driver Anna. Around the same time, two persons entered the house through the back door. They were Shubha and Nero. However, Mridula clarified to the police that she had no clue about their identity at that point of time. She watched the development without a word. She felt Sivarasan had sensed that she was not happy about the arrival of the new guests. She said she and Ranganath could not sleep that night.[1]

Next morning, when she went out to collect milk from the regular vendor, she noticed a green Maruti Gypsy parked in front of her house, partially covered in tarpaulin. Ranganath, Suresh Master and Rangan left after having coffee. Rangan and Suresh Master returned in the afternoon with bags full of groceries. That night, when her husband returned, Mridula said she sensed something fishy about the guests. ‘Why are these people so hesitant to go out?’ she asked Ranganath. ‘Just ignore these things. They are here just for three or four days. After that they will leave.’

After four days, Mridula received the biggest shock of her life. Photographs of Sivarasan and Shubha were broadcast on television news.